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H2 Sunday, Dec. 19, 1999 ★★★★★ PERSONAL TECHNOLOGY The Atlanta Journal-Constitution

Netwatch

YOUR WEEKLY ONLINE GUIDE

■ Y2K AND MILLENNIUM SITES

Y2K.Com: Online news site C|Net snagged this Web address and has used it to post a useful and comprehensive resource. Download software to test your home PC. Evaluate competing claims of the doomsayers and pooh-poohers. Buy survival gear, if you are so inclined.
➤ www.y2k.com

American Red Cross: A basic readiness checklist includes keeping some money and supplies on hand and at least half a tank of gas in the car. But where are you going?
➤ www.redcross.org/disaster/safety/y2k.html

Y2K Gateway: The government has a way of complicating everything, but this site attempts to bore a "gateway" into the bureaucracy that has grown up to address the Y2K crisis.
➤ www.itpolicy.gsa.gov/mks/yr2000/y2khome.htm

President's Council on Year 2000: Among the best of the government Y2K sites is the one for the President's Council on Year 2000 Conversion.
➤ www.y2k.gov

Y2K For Kids: The government that once taught us to put our heads under the school desk in case of an atomic bomb blast says of the Y2K bug, "You might not notice it, but little things may happen."
➤ www.itpolicy.gsa.gov/mks/yr2000/kidsy2k.htm

Microsoft Year 2000 Portal Page: Here's the corporate doublespeak. "Windows 95 and Windows 98 are compliant," states one of the opening pages at this site. But click on the phrase, and you get a little elaboration. Your operating system is compliant "assuming all recommended actions specified in the respective compliance documents have been taken." Oh, and good luck finding those documents and taking the actions specified.
➤ www.microsoft.com/y2k/

Gary North's: The doomsayers are alive and well and living online. One of the most extreme is Gary North. Societal collapse and martial law will result from an inevitable Y2K meltdown, he says. His solution: "Do what you can, while you still can, to locate your home out of any future battle zone."
➤ www.garynorth.com/

Gary South: North has his detractors, as evidenced by this spoof site.
➤ www.garysouth.com/

The Millennium Contagion: Here is a scholarly look at the problem of "self-spreading" ideas, in particular, the fear of a Y2K apocalypse.
➤ www.mcs.net/~aaron/tmc.htm

■ ON THE JOB

Nurse Jobz: We remember Nurse Jobz. (Very helpful in the operating room, she was.) No, this offering provides job listings for RNs, LPNs, nurse managers and clinical specialists. It offers a searchable database, employer profiles and online applications.
➤ www.nursejobz.com/

I-Resign.Com: If you can't figure out how to quit a job, maybe you don't deserve to have one. Regardless, this site offers tips on the fine art of quitting and finding jobs, as well as resignation letters by the witty and famous.
➤ www.i-resign.com/ok/home/default.asp

Churchstaffing.Com: "You're gonna have to serve somebody," Bob Dylan said. Never more true than in the clerical profession. Churchstaffing.com features job listings and résumés for pastors, musicians, youth directors and other church professionals in the United States and overseas (a recent ad pumped a pastoral post on Grand Cayman island).
➤ www.churchstaffing.com/churchstaffing/index.html

■ TECHNOLOGY AND THE NET

My PDA News.com: Personal digital assistants are all about electronic convenience. This site helps further that goal with a directory of news stories, reviews, message board sites and PDA-related articles.
➤ www.mypdanews.com/

Ultimate Internet Wedding Guide: This Web ring of wedding professionals aims to promote their talents, styles and businesses. (We liked the all-fern wedding.) All you brides and grooms to be! Remember, even when it comes to cake and ice cream, it pays to shop around.
➤ www.ultimateweddding.com/vendors/webring.htm

Final Exam: The Future of Computing: The material on this site comes from a final exam a teacher gave to college students taking a special advanced course on The Future of Computing. It contains thought-provoking questions about Internet technologies and regulations that try to tame the "Wild West nature" of the Web. Content is straight text but worth the read.
➤ www.skyhunter.com/marcs/finalexam.html

Operation Web Webmaster Resources: This simple, straightforward "service center" lays out all of the information, links and resources needed for Webmasters to create and operate successful sites. Topics range from Java script to e-mail marketing.
➤ www.operationweb.com/

Synclt.Com: This new site allows visitors to bookmark favorite sites on their PC and synchronize them with multiple computers.
➤ www.Synclt.com

Productopia: Holiday buying can get so confusing. How do you judge one portable, self-contained, solar-powered pith helmet/hammock/field bathtub against another? Productopia aims to clarify purchase decisions with third-party assessments of top products in hundreds of categories.
➤ www.productopia.com

■ TRIVIA, TRUE FACTS AND FUN

Deb and Jan's Land O'Useless Fact: Did you know that carnivorous animals will not eat another animal that has been hit by a lightning strike? Learn a new useless fact every day. If that's not enough, browse the Useless Fact Archives.
➤ www.useless-facts.com/

Presidential Useless Facts: William Howard Taft was our last president with facial hair. Jimmy Carter was the first president born in a hospital. Gerald Ford was born Leslie Lynch King Jr. Theodore Roosevelt's wife and mother died on the same day. If it's trivial and presidential, this site probably has it.
➤ members.xoom.com/_XOOM/uselessfacts/potususeless.htm

Trivia Cafe Question of the Day: Sometimes it's nice to have your trivia portioned out in daily bites. Sample: Which 1995 film did Michelle Pfeiffer play an ex-Marine teaching problematic students at a tough Los Angeles school? You could look it up.
➤ www.triviacafe.com/ques_day.html

History Channel This Day in History: Not only does the well-respected History Channel give you the day's events, it allows you to search their archive to match events with dates. You can also explore all the exciting events that have occurred on your birthday (your birth probably not being one of them).
➤ www.historychannel.com/tdih/

Black Facts Online: Black history information is searchable by date and topic at this easy-to-navigate site. The music file that plays when you enter the site, though, really must be stopped.
➤ www.blackfacts.com/

Literary Calendar: Bookworms always want to know what year "War and Peace" was published or which Bronte sister was born on which day. This almanac of literary information lets you browse specific days, search the entries or join the mailing list for daily e-mails of historical tidbits.
➤ fiscal.yasuda-u.ac.jp/

Sports Trivia From Yesteryear: There's trivia, and then there's the obsessive land of sports trivia. This site offers a daily trivia quiz on football, basketball, baseball, tennis, golf, hockey and soccer. But it isn't too obsessive. Typical question: Modern basketball's birthplace in 1891 was Springfield. But which Springfield should we think — Springfield, Ill., or Springfield, Mass.?
➤ www.wigal.com/main.asp?frum=2000?&sow2

Fun Trivia.com: This is one of the most comprehensive trivia sites on the Web, featuring fun facts, chat rooms, contests (you can win money, by the way), newsletters, links to other sites and a huge archive of questions and answers. A seasonal sample: Charles Dickens' initial choice for Scrooge's statement "Bah Humbug" was "Bah Christmas." It's a fact.
➤ funtrivia.com/

MP3.com, Slate flourished during a notable Web year

NETW@TCHER
FRANCES KATZ
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End-of-the-year lists are as inevitable as death and taxes. At the end of the century, it's a good thing the Web isn't 1,000 years old or even 10. This subjective list of 1999's notable Web achievements won't make anybody think back further than January.

Upset of the year: MP3.com (www.mp3.com)

It's just amazing how one Web site can single-handedly turn the music industry upside down. MP3.com's extensive collection of downloadable digital music, combined with the music industry's initial reluctance to release music for sale via the Web, created a demand for digital music that can no longer be ignored.

Most improved player: Slate (www.slate.com)

After so much hype, so many misfires and a failed subscription plan, Slate has finally found its way in the online world. Its thoughtful political coverage and stable of experienced writers have transformed Slate from Microsoft's and Editor Michael Kinsley's goofy hobby to a Web site actually worth reading. Expect sparks to fly as election 2000 shifts into high gear.

Best use of a chat room: Atlanta office worker "Hey Y'all"

While hiding under her desk in an Atlanta office building, Leigh Frey signed on to the CNN current events chat room using the pseudonym "Hey Y'all." She used the chat room to get the latest news about gunman Mark O. Barton's shooting spree in the Piedmont Center office complex where she worked. Other chatters were skeptical but provided needed information and words of encouragement. Proof that community on the Web isn't just about geeky teenage boys looking for love.

Best search engine that just searches: (www.google.com)

It's just one page with a box to type in your query. No free e-mail, no online shopping, no chat rooms, no message boards. There's nothing to do here but search the Web, and the results are good. You click, you search, you read. Portals are like, you know, so five minutes ago.

Best place to try and make a quick buck: eBay (www.ebay.com)

From human body parts to souvenirs of the World Trade Organization riots in Seattle, eBay proves that Web auctions are an endless source of fascination, a great source for obscure collectibles and an outlet for every scam artist around. EBay catches most of them, but not before the media have a field day.

Best example that two heads really are better than one — and get more attention, too: MindSpring/EarthLink, EarthLink/MindSpring merger

I say tomato, you say tomahto; however you look at it, it's still going to be the second-largest Internet service provider after behemoth America Online. With 3 million subscribers and a prototype deal with AT&T for open access to cable lines, the MindSpring/EarthLink combo may have extended the potential lifespan of the ISP well into the 21st century.

Best candidate for induction into the Silicon Valley Boys Club: CMGI President David Wetherell

When Lycos tried to merge with Barry Diller and Ticketmaster, majority stockholder Wetherell was there to quash the deal. He then snapped up failing search engine AltaVista and reinvented it as a shopping and services site, and he's not done yet. The Massachusetts businessman proves you don't need offices in Palo Alto to play the Web game and win.

Best argument for holiday shopping at the mall: e-toys.com, Toysrus.com, kbkids.com. (tie)

Not even little Cindy-Lou Who could save millions of online shoppers from frustration, disappointment, out-of-stock items and poor customer service. Why toy retailers were unprepared for one of their biggest seasons of the year is a mystery they need to solve before December 2000.

Best online example that war is hell: The first-person accounts of the war in Kosovo from Belgrade radio station B92 (www.freeb92.net)

Many called the war in Kosovo the first Internet war as millions of Bosnians took to their laptops and described the NATO bombing of Belgrade. Their stories were often-chilling accounts of life during wartime that won't be easily forgotten.

'Donkey Kong 64' a winner

DALLAS MORNING NEWS

Nintendo's Gameboy Color unit may be as rare as ben's teeth this holiday season, but the first gorilla in video games, "Donkey Kong," is swinging into action on the Nintendo 64 in a big way. One word can best describe the ape's newest adventure — gargantuan!

The cantankerous crocodile King K. Rool has set his sights on destroying Donkey Kong's island home. K. Rool's reptile minions have stolen Donkey Kong's golden bananas, and now the ape must embark on the biggest Nintendo 64 3-D adventure yet.

Once Donkey Kong rescues his four primate pals — Diddy, Lanky, Tiny and Chunky — they can join him on his quest.

No doubt about it, "Donkey Kong 64" is huge — even bigger than other 3-D adventures such as "Zelda," "Banjo-Kazooie" and "Super Mario 64." Each Kong character has special moves: Diddy flies with a jetpack, Tiny fits into small places and Chunky lifts boulders. You'll have to use all their skills to get every golden banana.

But getting there is half the fun, and that's where the game shines. To get the golden bananas, you'll swing on vines, blast out of cannons and ride a roller coaster. Banana bonus games abound, too, and include target practice and beaver herding. You can even play the classic "Donkey Kong" arcade game from the early '80s.

The game's sheer size and complexity may overwhelm some gamers. But control is excellent, and players will gradually learn new abilities. "Donkey Kong 64" requires the included Expansion Pak. It sports some of the best graphics ever for the N64, with ever-changing lighting and detailed environments.

Sounds are also top-notch, with catchy music and tons of voices. Finally, the nifty two- to four-player battle mode makes "Donkey Kong 64" the game to get this holiday season.

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